

# Lab 0: Environment Gate

**Duration:** 25 min (self-paced, complete BEFORE Day 1 Block 1 ends)

**Difficulty:** Setup

**Deliverable:** A machine that passes every check below and shows the marker **YOU ARE READY**.

## Objective

Sign in with your organization identity, install Claude Code with the native installer, and confirm your environment is green before the first lab. Nothing in Day 1 works until this does.

**START MARKER:** *You have a terminal open and can type commands.*

## Step 0 (OPTIONAL): Already Using Claude Code? Start Clean (5 min)

**Skip this if today is your first install.** If you already run Claude Code day to day, your personal setup - a global `~/.claude/CLAUDE.md`, hooks, plugins, installed skills, custom settings - will change what Claude does in these labs. Your output will not match the room's, and you will spend lab time chasing a difference that is your config, not the tool.

The fix is a throwaway profile. `CLAUDE_CONFIG_DIR` redirects **all** Claude Code configuration - credentials, settings, skills, plugins, hooks, and `CLAUDE.md` - to a different directory. Set it in the terminal you will use for class:

**Windows (PowerShell):**

```
$env:CLAUDE_CONFIG_DIR = "$HOME\.claude-teach"
```

**macOS / Linux (bash/zsh):**

```
export CLAUDE_CONFIG_DIR="$HOME/.claude-class"
```

Then launch `claude` and complete the sign-in flow again. **A fresh profile means a fresh sign-in** - your normal credentials live in the old directory, so the new one starts logged out. That is expected, not an error.

The variable only applies to the terminal session you set it in. Open a new terminal without it and plain `claude` uses your normal setup, untouched. Nothing is deleted.

**Why this is a real technique, not just a classroom trick:**

- It is how you **test risky config safely** - a new hook, an unvetted plugin, a permission rule you are not sure about. Try it in a throwaway profile before it touches your daily driver.

- It is how you **bisect "is it my config or the tool?"** - reproduce the problem in a clean profile. Still broken? It's the tool. Works fine? It's something in your config, and now you know where to look.

**Expected output marker:** `claude` launches, asks you to sign in, and `/doctor` reports a clean profile with no user-level customizations loaded.

## Step 1: Identity and Access Check (5 min)

Everyone in this class is on the **enterprise plan** - there are no licensing or plan-tier decisions to make today. You only need to prove you are signed in under the right identity.

1. Confirm the exact work email/identity approved for the course.
2. Sign in with that identity. Do not substitute a personal account.

3. Launch Claude Code. If access is denied, stop and contact the training coordinator with the exact error.
4. Once signed in, run `/model` to confirm the live model configuration on this machine.

**Expected output marker:** Claude Code opens under the approved organization identity.

## Step 2: Install Claude Code - Native Installer (10 min)

*Claude Code no longer requires Node.js or npm. The npm install path was deprecated in January 2026. Use the native installer for your OS. Windows runs natively - no WSL required.*

**macOS / Linux:**

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

or Homebrew:

```
brew install --cask claude-code # or use the curl one-liner above
```

**Windows (PowerShell):**

```
winget install Anthropic.ClaudeCode
```

Windows (PowerShell one-liner, self-updating - preferred):

```
irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex
```

**Linux package managers:** `apt`, `dnf`, and `apk` packages are also available - see the install docs at [code.claude.com](https://code.claude.com).

Verify:

```
claude --version
```

**Expected output marker:** A current stable version, with **v2.1.219 or later** required for every model and orchestration feature taught in this course. Run `claude update` if needed. If you see `command not found`, close and reopen your terminal so PATH updates take effect.

## Step 3: Git + VS Code Check (3 min)

```
git --version
```

**Expected:** `git version 2.x.x`

```
code --version
```

**Expected:** A VS Code version number. (VS Code is optional but recommended - the extension bundles the CLI. Terminal-only is fully supported.)

**For the lab sample project only** (not for Claude Code itself):

```
node -v
```

**Expected:** `v18.x` or higher. The Day 1 build project uses Node/Express. If Node is missing, install the LTS from [nodejs.org](https://nodejs.org).

## Step 4: Create the Course Workspace (2 min)

The first hands-on lab creates the `business-dashboard` project from scratch, so no external sample repository is required.

```
mkdir claude-code-training
cd claude-code-training
git init
```

**Expected output marker:** Git reports an initialized repository in the empty course workspace.

## Step 5: First Launch + `/doctor Green` (5 min)

```
claude
```

1. Complete the sign-in flow **with the identity from Step 1**.
2. When the prompt appears, run:

```
/doctor
```

**Expected output marker:** All checks green. The July 2026 `/doctor` runs a full diagnostic and can auto-fix common problems - if anything shows yellow/red, press `f` to auto-fix, then re-run `/doctor`.

3. Confirm the default model:

```
/model
```

**Expected output marker: Sonnet 5 appears in the list and is selectable.** Sonnet 5 is the class default - every lab assumes it. If Sonnet 5 is not listed, flag it now; do not wait until Lab 1A.

4. Exit for now:

```
exit
```

## FINISH MARKER - YOU ARE READY

If every box below is checked, you are ready for Lab 1A:

- ☐ Approved organization identity launches Claude Code successfully
- ☐ `claude --version` returns v2.1.219+ - **write your version number here:** \_\_\_\_\_

(Tell the instructor if you are on a notably older build. Checkpoints/rewind and `/doctor` auto-fix are recent additions - an old build will not behave like the room's.)

- ☐ `git --version` works
- ☐ Node 18+ present (for the lab project)
- ☐ Empty course workspace initialized with git
- ☐ `/doctor` all green
- ☐ `/model` shows **Sonnet 5** available and selectable
- ☐ (Optional, returning users) `CLAUDE_CONFIG_DIR` set to a clean class profile and re-authenticated

**YOU ARE READY.**

## If Stuck

| Problem                                                              | Recovery                                                                                                                     |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>claude: command not found</code> after install                 | Close and reopen the terminal; on Windows, sign out/in or check PATH in System Settings                                      |
| Sign-in loop / wrong account                                         | Run <code>claude /logout</code> , then <code>claude</code> and use the Step 1 identity                                       |
| <code>/doctor</code> shows red items                                 | Press <code>f</code> for auto-fix; if still red, screenshot and post in the class channel                                    |
| Corporate proxy blocks install                                       | Ask IT to allow <code>claude.ai</code> and <code>code.claude.com</code> , or use the offline installer from your coordinator |
| Access denied or wrong organization                                  | Capture the exact error and escalate to the coordinator; do not switch to a personal account                                 |
| Set <code>CLAUDE_CONFIG_DIR</code> and now Claude asks me to sign in | Correct - a fresh profile is a fresh sign-in. Sign in again with the same organization identity                              |
| My results don't match the room's                                    | You are probably on your normal profile with personal <code>hooks/plugins/CLAUDE.md</code> loaded. Do Step 0                 |
| Want my normal setup back                                            | Open a new terminal without <code>CLAUDE_CONFIG_DIR</code> set. Nothing was deleted                                          |

## Debrief Questions

1. What does `CLAUDE_CONFIG_DIR` actually redirect - and why does that make it a safe way to test a risky hook or plugin?
2. Why does the native installer matter compared to the old npm path?
3. What does `/doctor`'s auto-fix (press `f`) actually change on your machine?